

Equus africanus somaliensis

Somali wild ass



Length 6¼–7 ft
(1.95–2.05 m)

Tail 16–18 in (40–45 cm)

Weight 600–620 lb
(270–280 kg)

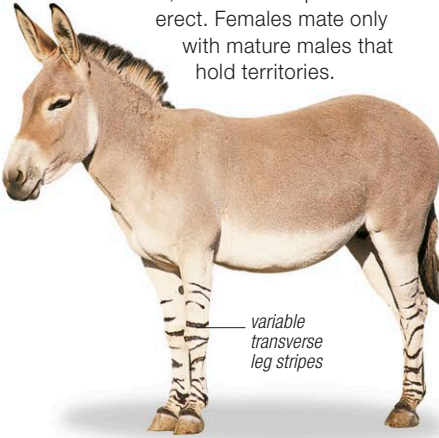
Social unit Group

Status Critically endangered

Location E. Africa



The Somali wild ass lives in rocky deserts where the ground temperature exceeds 122° F (50° C). It eats almost any plant food, from grasses to thorny acacia bushes, and goes without water for several days. The upperparts are buff-gray in summer and iron-gray in winter; the mane is sparse but erect. Females mate only with mature males that hold territories.



Equus hemionus

Onager



Length 6½–8¼ ft
(2–2.5 m)

Tail 12–19½ in
(30–49 cm)

Weight 440–570 lb
(200–260 kg)

Social unit Group

Status Near threatened

Location W., C., and S. Asia



This Asian wild ass eats a variety of vegetation, including grasses and succulent plants. Females and young onagers form loose, wandering herds, while immature males gather in bachelor groups. Solitary mature males kick and bite rivals to occupy the territory they need for breeding. Mainly buff, tawny, or gray in coloration, the onager is white underneath, with a dark mane, back stripe, ear tips, and feathered tail tip.

Equus przewalskii

Przewalski's horse



Length 7¼–8½ ft
(2.2–2.6 m)

Tail 32–43 in
(80–110 cm)

Weight 440–660 lb
(200–300 kg)

Social unit Group

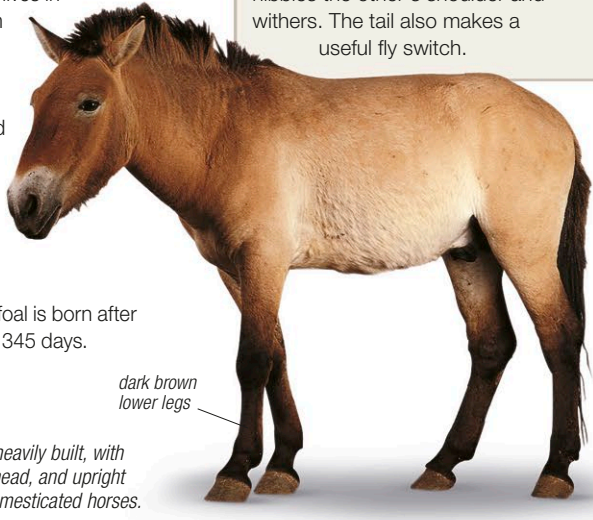
Status Endangered

Location Reintroduced to C. Asia

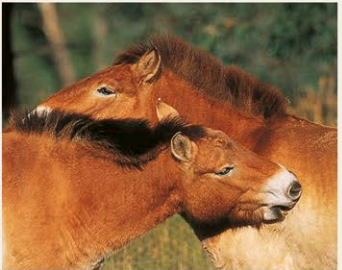


This horse now survives mainly in zoos, parks, and field stations. Although it has been reintroduced in Mongolia, it faces problems, such as crossbreeding with domestic horses. It lives in cohesive, long-term herds that wander great distances for grass, leaves, and buds. A typical herd is led by senior mare and has 2–4 other mares, their offspring, and one stallion who stays on the periphery. A single foal is born after a gestation of 333–345 days.

SMALL BUT STOCKY
Przewalski's horse is heavily built, with a thick neck, a large head, and upright mane compared to domesticated horses.



MUTUAL GROOMING



Social grooming is important for this species, as for most wild equids, serving to reinforce herd bonds. Usually 2 animals stand nose to tail so that they can look out for danger in both directions, and each nibbles the other's shoulder and withers. The tail also makes a useful fly switch.

Equus grevyi

Grevy's zebra



Length 8¼–9¾ ft
(2.5–3 m)

Tail 15–23½ in
(38–60 cm)

Weight 770–990 lb
(350–450 kg)

Social unit Group

Status Endangered

Location E. Africa



The largest zebra and biggest wild equid, Grevy's zebra has dense, narrow stripes that remain distinct all the way down to the hooves; the belly and tail base are white. Males occupy huge territories, up to 4 square miles (10 square km). Females and foals roam freely, perhaps gathering in small, loose herds to graze, but there are no long-term herd bonds.



Equus quagga

Plains zebra



Length 7¼–8¼ ft
(2.2–2.5 m)

Tail 18½–22 in
(47–56 cm)

Weight 390–850 lb
(175–385 kg)

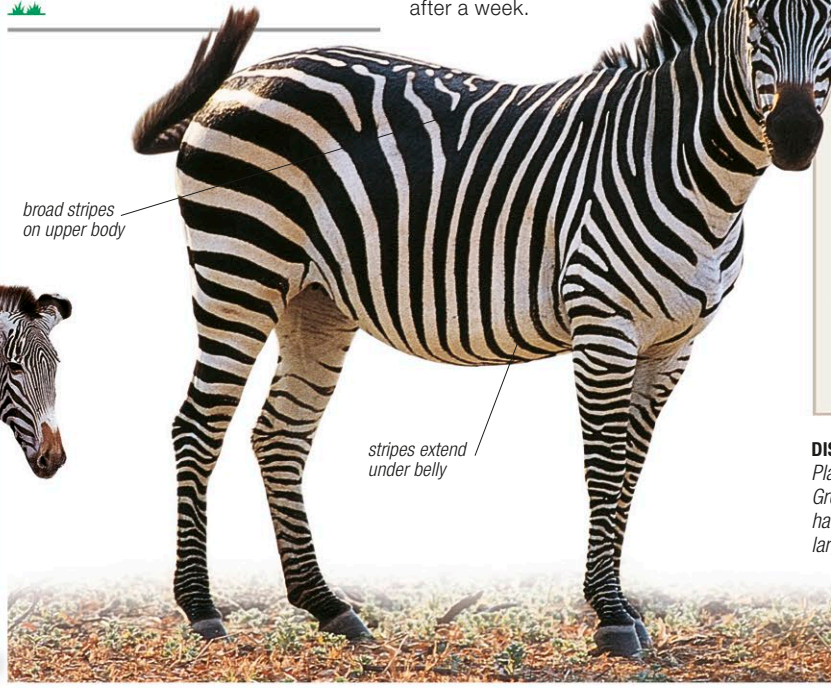
Social unit Group

Status Near threatened

Location E. and southern Africa



This successful and widespread zebra has a diet of nine-tenths grass; the remainder is leaves and buds. The main, long-term social unit is a stallion, his harem of one or several mares, and their offspring. Maturing stallions form loose bachelor herds and may challenge for the harem with fierce fights of biting and kicking. The single foal can stand within a few minutes of birth and is grazing after a week.



FLEHMEN RESPONSE



A plains zebra stallion, like other male equids, curls up his top lip in order to heighten his sense of smell. Known as the flehmen response or, more colloquially, the "horse laugh," this behavior is usually seen when the male (stallion) assesses the readiness of a female (mare) for breeding. By this means, he is able to detect certain scents in the mare's urine to determine if she is receptive for mating. The flehmen response may also occur if an individual picks up a strange scent.

DISTINCTIVE STRIPES
Plains zebra has a different stripe pattern from Grevy's (see left). Some subspecies of zebra have faint "shadow" stripes between the large flank stripes.